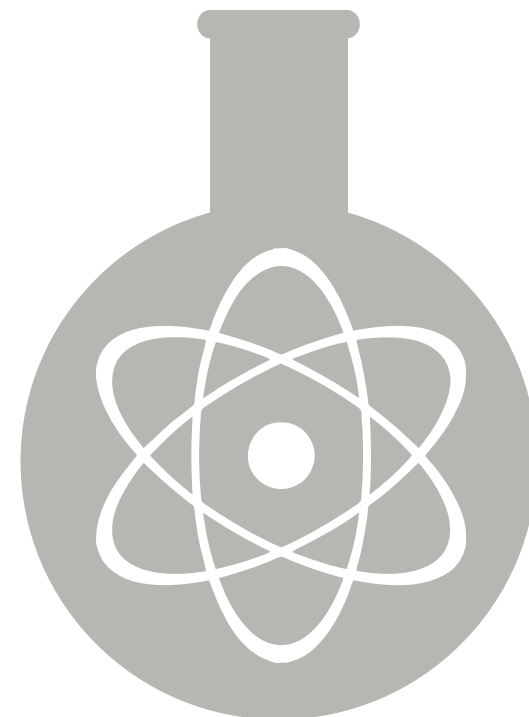




HOW

to

TEST

The Landing Page

Testing Success Guide

Introduction

One of the most common statements we hear from marketers is, “I want to test, but I don’t really know how to get started.” And it’s no wonder! While landing page testing is fairly straightforward to execute (it’s not exactly rocket science, is it?), getting your landing page tests off the ground can be daunting. Where to test? When to test? What to test? What was learned from the test?

Reading best practices, buying tools, and sitting around a table talking about testing doesn’t equate to actually doing it. And doing it can feel just too darn hard.

Have no fear, help is here! How To Test is your plan of action, taking you through the steps to get your landing page tests off the ground. We’ve outlined everything you need to do to decide where to test, what to test and how to test. Following these steps will help you be organized, methodical and agile.

Landing page testing is fun, so don’t forget to smile once in a while!



Introduction



Plans, not tools.

This workbook is focused on the executional steps (not the tools) for planning your landing page tests from start to finish. For more on tools, check out ion's Landing Page Software Buyer's Guide.



New to testing?

If you are new to testing, you may also want to read ion's Guide to Online Testing for an introduction to important testing concepts.



Already testing your landing pages? No problem!

Think of this guide as spring cleaning for your landing page testing program. Sure, this success guide is designed for marketers who are new to testing. But even if you are already conducting landing page tests, you'll still find good advice and action items here to apply to your program. Get out your broom and mop — let's get to work.



Campaign landing pages, not website landing pages.

*What's a landing page? It's anywhere a web visitor might land after they click one of your ads, messages or links. There are 2 landing page categories —SEO & campaign. An **SEO landing page** is a page within your site that a visitor lands on after clicking an organic search result. A **campaign landing page** is a landing page that is created specifically for advertising for the express purpose of getting a visitor to take a specific action like filling out a form, downloading a white paper, signing up for a free trial or making a purchase. This workbook is for executing your campaign landing page tests.*

Step 1: Traffic



Where should you test?

Methodical testing comes from methodical thinking. So, while it seems logical to start landing page testing by evaluating your pages, we actually recommend starting with your traffic. There's no testing without traffic. Your entire testing program revolves around testing landing experiences on your live traffic. Get your arms around the scope of your traffic in order to identify the biggest areas of opportunity.

Do you have enough traffic to test?



Well, it depends. It's true—no traffic, no testing. How much traffic you have, across how many unique sources of traffic, will influence how many tests you can conduct, and how often.

Don't let small traffic volumes hold you back from testing. Launch innovative test waves at 80% confidence to maximize potential for quicker

results. It may take weeks, or even months, to get results, but at least you will be testing!

To anticipate how long a test may take to run, use one of the many free test duration calculators available online. As long as you expect to get statistically confident results within 8 weeks, go ahead and run the test! Make sure you only test two things at once—your control and your challenger—and make them as different from each other as you can.

So, let's get started by evaluating your traffic. You can do this exercise as granularly as you wish. If you want to get your arms around all your potential areas for testing across your entire online

marketing program, then your traffic types will likely be big buckets, like display, email, search, social. If you want to focus on just testing within one of those buckets, then your traffic types will likely be

Step 1: Traffic

categories within those buckets (like Twitter, Facebook, LinkedIn in the case of social).

This is an important step. You may be saying to yourself, “But I have this information available in a report, why do I need to do this step?” It’s the process of organizing your thinking around your traffic sources that is important. So, if you would rather just print out a report and take a look at it, that’s ok too. The point of this step is to

start at traffic, not at pages. Get your arms around all the types of traffic that you are responsible for, so you can compare and contrast what’s happening at each of those sources in order to find the best place to start testing.

In order to do that, you’ll want to see how things are performing in the big picture.

How are your pages performing?

	Monthly Unique Visitors	Bounce Rate	Conversion Rate	Cost Per Lead Per Conversion
Paid Search				
Email, Paid				
Display				
Social				
Email, House				

Step 1: Traffic

Once you have done this exercise, stand back and take a look:

1. Where are you getting the most traffic?

High traffic can be a testing opportunity, because you will be more likely to have enough traffic to conduct a series of tests quickly. This may also be where the bulk of your budget goes, and maximizing the return of that budget is a great idea.

2. Where is your lowest conversion rate?

Low conversion traffic can be a testing opportunity because you likely have room for improvement and may get some conversion lifts quickly.

3. Where is your highest cost per conversion, or cost per lead?

Traffic that produces high acquisition cost can be a testing opportunity to make that budget more efficient and increase revenue from the resulting conversion improvement.

4. Where is your highest cost per click?

High cost per click can be a testing opportunity because each of these clicks is like gold—if the clicks are costly, they take up more room in your budget. You want to maximize every chance

you can to get those clicks to convert and to make that portion of your budget more efficient.

5. What is strategically, or even tactically, important to you?

This is an often overlooked area to evaluate when considering where to start testing. There may be factors at work inside your organization, in the market, and in your competitive landscape that should influence your consideration of what type of traffic you should start testing on first.

Okay, now decide... what type of traffic are you going to start testing? There's no right answer or right approach. You have to weigh the points above and decide what's most important to you. To get cost per conversion down? To get conversions up where your cost per click is the highest? To crush your competitors in the quest for paid search customer acquisition? Some intersection of the above? Give this decision some time, but also, don't get stuck on it. Pick one and let's move on to step two.

Step 1: Traffic

What's it all mean?

Once you have your types of traffic identified, what do you do with this information? So, traffic is low on email, but your conversion rate is high. Traffic is high on display, but conversions are low and your cost per conversion is horrible. Your social traffic is in the middle, but conversions are high and cost per conversion is low. What's it all mean? How do you sift through it in order to pick where you will start testing? Take into consideration:

Unless you are a high volume sender, email traffic can be more challenging to start. Email traffic comes in spurts, so when you test your email landing pages you will be going for learning that you will use in the long-term, rather than an immediate conversion lift.

Paid search traffic on the other hand, tends to be the easiest place to start. With paid search, your audience is searching for solutions, answers and products. Incoming traffic tends to be fairly steady and predictable, so you can cycle through tests designed for both conversion improvement and learning.

Display traffic on the other hand, comes in a steady & predictable fashion, but the visitors aren't necessarily looking for what you offer in that exact moment the way they are with search. Display traffic often has quasi-interest in you, rather

than immediate intent. Display traffic offers great opportunity for conversion lift, but can take longer to get momentum while you cycle through several learning test waves to determine more about what works on the incoming traffic.

With low traffic, your testing approach will be slow & steady; starting off with an innovative test wave (more on that later), designed not for learning, but for big conversion improvement. Your innovative test will incorporate all common best practices, and it will run to 80% statistical confidence. This might take weeks, or even months, but that's okay. You'll take what you learn in the test wave and apply it to the next.

With high traffic, your testing approach will be more rapid & iterative. You'll want to be a well-oiled machine of test planning and analysis so you can continually launch tests & apply learnings. Once your testing is off the ground, you'll be tempted to skip some of the steps outlined in this success guide, but stay the course. You don't want to end up with a 'throw it against the wall and see what sticks' testing culture.





Step 2: Messages

Okay, but where specifically should you test?

It's not as easy as completing step 1 and saying, "Great, I'm testing on my paid search." Step 1 helped you identify your areas of opportunity and priorities. But, within a type of traffic, there are any number of unique messages and traffic sources. This is where it gets messy.

You wouldn't go launch a single landing page test for all your paid search traffic, or one single landing page for every email you send. That would probably lead to a failed test, at best. You'll need to take the traffic evaluation one step further and determine which unique streams of traffic you want to test on within the traffic type.

You probably have a lot of very unique messages out there. It may be impossible for you to document every single ad message you have within your source, especially if you are starting with paid search. You'll need to think in terms of buckets of messages or offers. This will help determine how many unique landing pages you'll need. For landing page conversion success, you want your ad and landing page to be as relevant to each other as possible. Ideally one landing page for every ad, but that's not realistic. For some PPC advertisers that might mean thousands of unique landing pages, and likely there would not be enough traffic on any one ad to support landing page testing. So rather than one landing page for one ad, you'll need to group ads & messages by how similar

they are, so you can send several ads to a single landing page test. On the streams of traffic within your traffic type, compare traffic volume, bounce rate, conversion rate, cost per lead or cost per conversion. Decide based on that inspection which specific source of traffic to test on. What is your greatest area of opportunity and also has enough traffic to sustain testing?

For more on this topic, check out the Landing Page Ratio.
<http://ioninteractive.com/post-click-marketing-blog/2008/5/6/landing-page-ratio-lpr.html>



PPC

If you are testing on PPC, you probably want to start on a high volume ad group. Just make sure the keywords & ads in the ad group are similar enough to maintain a high degree of relevancy on the landing pages. If the keywords and ads are very different from each other within the ad

Step 2: Messages

group, you will want to get more granular and run several landing page tests at once within the ad group.



Email

If you are testing on email traffic, remember that each email drop tends to be different, so you probably want to run a unique landing page test for every email you drop. Again, you are going for a very high degree of relevancy between the email and the landing page. Structure these tests to learn something from each test on each email drop, and use that learning to feed into the next test wave for the next drop. Tests build on each other.



Display

If you are testing on display, both visual and message match between the ads and landing pages is very important. Display traffic needs to recognize instantly that they landed in the right place after they clicked your ad, so the landing page should mirror the ad copy and visuals.

This step is unique for each company. The point is you have to think about your messages leading to your pages to really determine exactly where you will test first.

Banner Ad

Message & Design Match

Landing Page

The image shows a banner ad and a landing page for Centrum Silver. The banner ad features the text 'A LANDMARK MULTIVITAMIN STUDY CHOSE CENTRUM® SILVER®' and 'CENTRUM. ALWAYS YOUR MOST COMPLETE.' with an image of a Centrum Silver bottle. The landing page features the Centrum logo, navigation links (PRODUCTS, HEALTH CENTER, FAQ, BUY), a 'FREE SAMPLE INFORMATION' button, and a 'BIG NEWS' section stating 'Centrum Silver® was part of the recently published landmark study evaluating the long-term benefits of multivitamins!'. Below this is a 'SAVE \$3' coupon section. At the bottom, there are four categories of Centrum products: SILVER 50+, UNDER 50, FLAVOR BURST, and SPECIALIST, each with corresponding product images.

Step 3: Pages

Now you know exactly where you are going to test. But what in the heck should you test!?

Smile, now the fun begins. You've decided very specifically where to test. But what will you test? This is where the rubber meets the road—the most important decision you will make.

It's easy to get carried away and start thinking about all the tests you want to run on all these different pages, across all these different traffic sources. That's usually where people stall. It's overwhelming. That's why we recommend you start with just one test, on just one page, for just one traffic source, or group of very similar traffic sources. Breaking your testing into manageable chunks, as you build testing competency, will help you be more successful in the long run.

As you start to think about what you want to test, evaluate the one page you are currently sending traffic to on your selected traffic source.

What is the bounce rate?

What is the conversion rate?

What is the conversion point?

What is the offer, or the reason to convert?

Is the page using common landing page best practices?



Here are a few really important landing page best practices to consider

Is there message match between the ad and landing page copy? Look for words and phrases that are used in the ad to be echoed on the landing page. Message match needs to be extremely obvious, not hidden or inferred.

Is there motivation match? This is a little more subtle than message match, but equally important. Every ad holds the promise of a 'carrot'. That's what gets the user motivated to click. The landing page needs to stay focused on the carrot and the visitor motivation.

Is the page actionable? The landing page needs to literally show the visitor what you want them to do. What's the action you want people to take on the

Step 3: Pages

Big picture, what elements of the page do you think are working well, and what are the areas of opportunity of improvement? This evaluation will lead you to selecting the right test approach.



No existing pages to test against?

What if you don't have a page yet or the test is for a new source of traffic? No problem—this information will still help you get organized about what you want to test when you move into the next step of documenting your test plan.

Controls, challengers and champions

In landing page testing, a control is whatever is currently live on your traffic source. It's the existing page you are sending traffic to. A challenger is the new page you launch to test against the control. A champion is a winner of a test. The champion of a test typically gets promoted to be the new control.



page? Don't be afraid to make it very visually obvious.

Is the page focused and simple? It's easy to clutter up a web page. Much harder to pare it down and keep it focused. But clarity leads to focus and focus leads to conversion. Stay on point—both the content and the visuals need to be clear, simple and focused.

Is the call to action positive? Users don't want to 'submit'. Don't make your call to action a command, make it something they want to do. Make it about the promise of your conversion. For example, use "Get started" instead of "Submit". Or "Download tips to boost performance" instead of "Download".

Is the copy scan-able? Copy-heavy pages are dense. Dense looks like work, and work doesn't convert. Use bullets and keep them short. Use subheads and short copy blocks. Vary your sentence length. Make sure your copy looks easy to scan and read.

Does the page make the user feel good? This is subjective, but important. Does it feel trustworthy? Is it visually appealing? Is it positive?

Step 3: Pages

A. Based on your evaluation of the page, decide what category of test you will run:

Design

With a design test, the content of the page stays largely the same, but the design elements change. Use a design test if you have strong message match, content and value proposition, but suspect the layout of the control page isn't conversion-focused enough.

Examples of a design test include:

- Page layout
- Form length or form style
- Images & icons
- Visual emphasis or directional cues

Relevancy

With a relevancy test, you will focus on increasing how relevant the page is to the ad. Use a relevancy test when you feel the overall conversion-focus of the page is strong, as are the design aspects, but the ad & page aren't message matched strongly enough. A relevancy test is a good place to start if your bounce rate is high (indicating the page isn't providing what the visitor expected).

- Increase message match by echoing the ad copy on the landing page
- Increase the visual match by mirroring imagery in the ad or email on the landing page

- Personalizing the page by displaying the keywords or visitor's name on the page can also lead to an increase in perceived relevancy

Content

If your design is conversion focused, and your message match is strong, you may want to alter the content on your page.

- Improve the value proposition and reason to convert
- Break the copy into more scannable chunks, varying sentence length, using bullets for emphasis
- Try more, or less, page copy
- Try accordions or tabbed content so visitors can click the content that is most interesting to them
- Remove some words—use an icon or image to represent some part of your message

Offer

Are you trying to convince visitors to convert for something that isn't that worthwhile? Asking them to sign up for a free trial, but not telling them why? Offering a white paper to someone who searched "download software"?

Step 3: Pages

- Change your offer to be more valuable or relevant to the target
- Sell it more—show the visitor what they get if they convert
- Ensure the value of what they are converting for is concordant with what you are asking them to do to convert

Experience

An experience test is a good idea when you feel like you need a fresh start, or need to try something very different.

- Test a microsite against a landing page
- Test a conversion path against a landing page
- Test a conversion path against a microsite
- Test two conversion paths against each other, each with very different 1st page segmentation choices
- And on and on!

Your landing pages should be disposable. Really.

Landing page testing requires that you are able to create a lot of pages quickly and have no anxiety over tossing out pages if they're not converting well.

In order to reduce this anxiety, pages can't be resource intensive. If your team spends a ton of time on one single page (layout, copy, images, coding, proofing, tweaking, etc), you won't be too happy when it doesn't win a test and you have to dump it. Better to make your landing pages disposable. Think minutes and hours, not days and weeks for new landing pages.

Understanding test waves

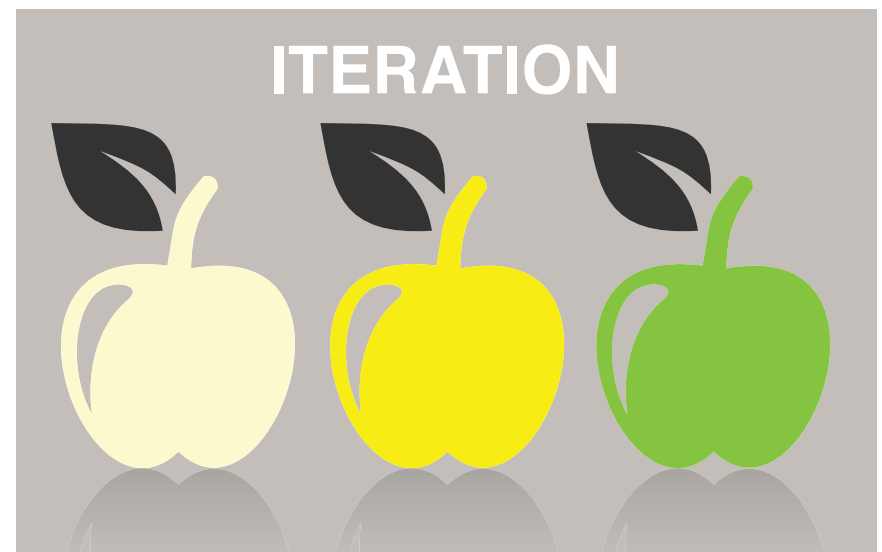
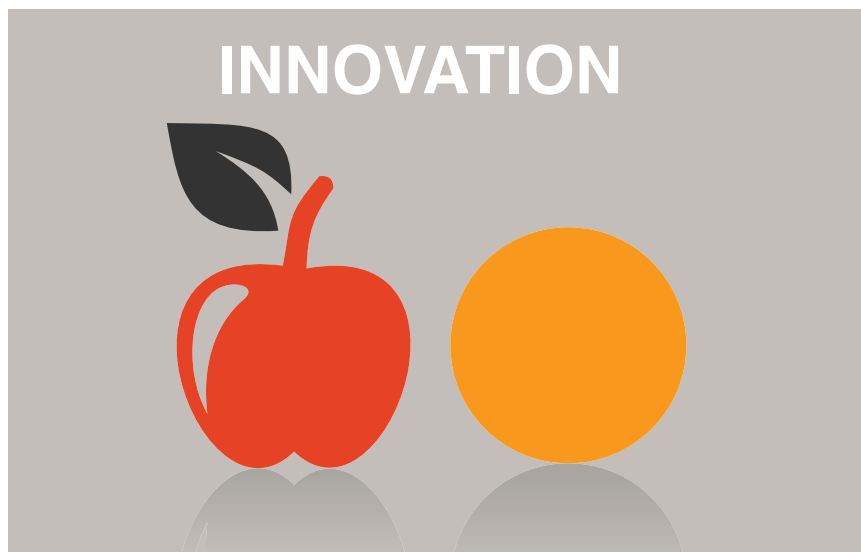
An innovative test wave tests two very different things against each other. In an innovative wave you are testing an apple against an orange. With this, you are testing to increase conversions, but learning from the test may be limited. You may be testing a microsite against a landing page. Or a short page of content against

a long page of content. It is hard to get learning out of a test like this. If you test an orange against an apple, and the apple wins, you don't know why (was it the flavor? the color? the shape? It doesn't matter as long as you have a winner that increased conversions!). After an innovative wave, you will move on to an

Step 3: Pages

iterative test wave. In an iterative test wave you are testing elements in the champion to try to lift conversions further. It's easier to get learnings from a wave like this—think about it as testing versions of apples against each other. You may be testing

different versions of a headline, or combinations of different images and buttons. Use an innovative test wave to get a big conversion lift from the test champion, then an iterative test wave to lift conversions even further from the champion.



A/B or MVT?

A/B. When you test an entire landing experience against at least one other landing experience, you're A/B testing. A/B/n is a way of noting that the test includes more than two alternatives, like A/B/C/D for a test that includes 4 landing experiences in a test group.

MVT or Multivariate Testing. When you test many combinations of elements within a single page — for example, versions of a headline & versions of images—you are multivariate testing.

Step 3: Pages

B. Is this test wave innovative or iterative?

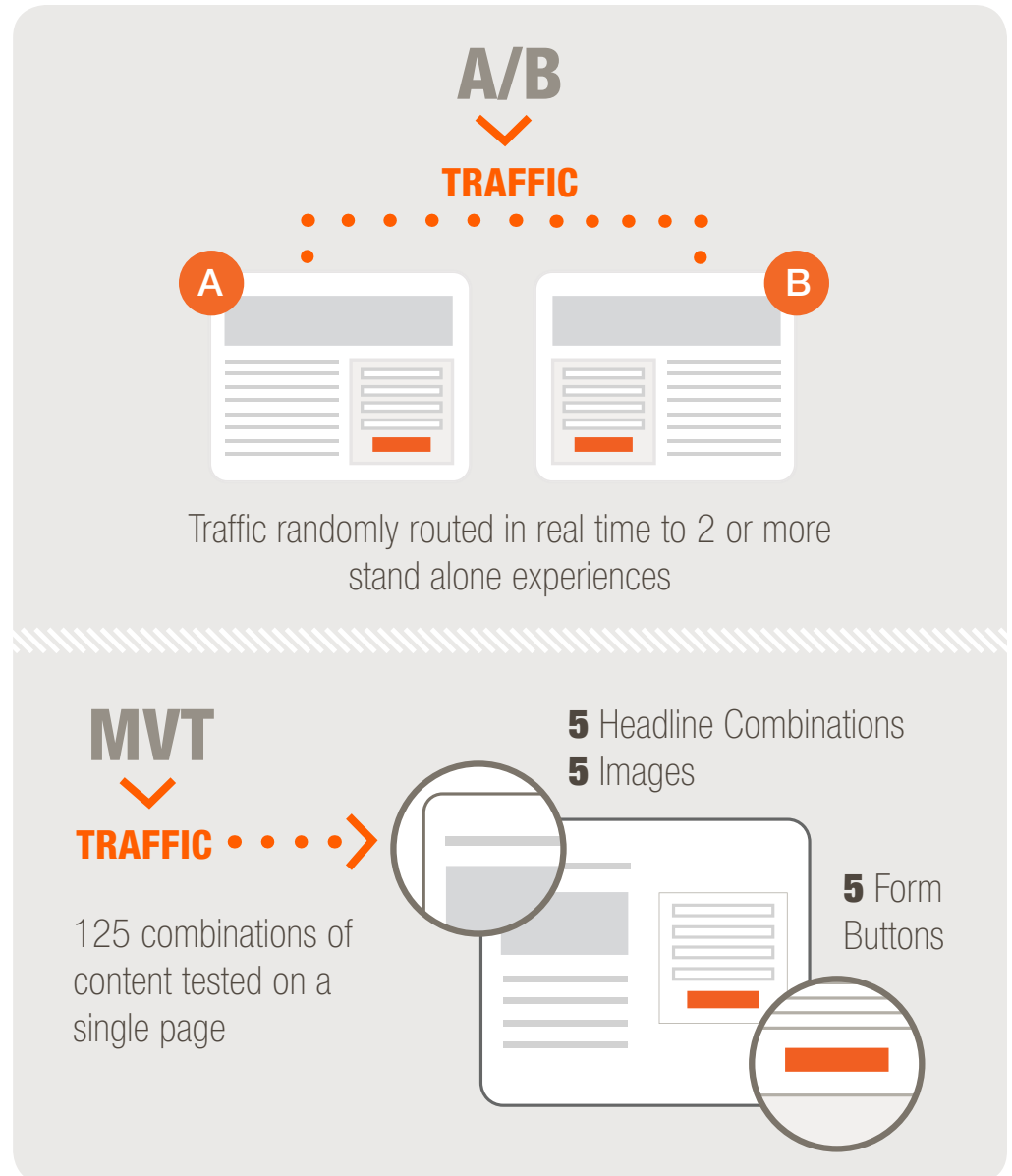
Decide in advance so you can alternate between the two as you progress into new test waves.

C. Will you be conducting an A/B or multivariate test?

At this stage, it's very easy to get stuck in analysis paralysis and overthink your test because you don't want to be 'wrong'. Don't worry about designing the perfect test. If you are prone to get stuck on the decision step, just execute. The wonderful thing about testing is that you will have real-time results, and the results will speak for themselves. You will know if your challenger isn't a winner, and if so, you'll move on to the next test wave.

With testing, inertia is a killer. Just GO!

When you have decided what type of test you will run, determined if it is an innovative or iterative wave, and decided on A/B or MVT, you are ready to create your test plan.



Step 4: Create your test plan



Now the easiest step—document your test plans

When you start testing, it is very easy to skip the test plan step. Don't be tempted! Documenting your test waves is a powerful way to help you ensure your testing approach is sound, and keeps track of all your tests over time. After you have been running tests for a year, across a variety of types of traffic and traffic sources, having all your test results in a handy, easily understood format will help you maintain your program momentum and ensure you don't backtrack and re-do tests you've already run (it can happen!).

Documenting your test plan is pretty easy.

Here's what's included in the test plan:

Who? Identify the target audience and their behavior or context leading to the page(s).

What? Describe the test in plain language.

Where? List the traffic source(s) you are running the test on.

When? When is the test going to launch, how long do you

anticipate it will run for, and to what level of statistical confidence are you testing?

Why? Describe your hypothesis for why you are running this test.

What happened? When the test concludes at statistical significance, document what happened. Don't skip this step! It's an important part of your record keeping.

Step 4: Create your test plan

Here's an example of what a test plan looks like:



A/B Test Plan

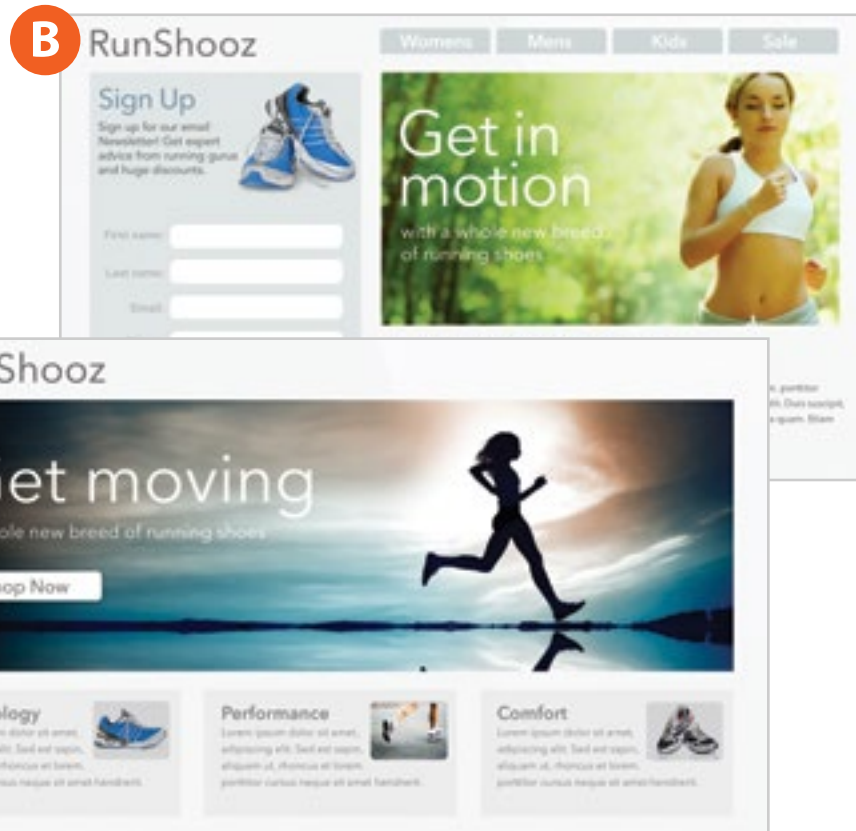
Who? Active women age 25-40 looking for performance gear.

What? A/B Test - A) Lightbox form page vs. B) Having the form directly on the landing page.

Where? Pay-per-click/content network traffic for Google and Bing.

When? Will run until 95% statistical significance is reached.

Why? Hypothesis is that a form on page will increase conversions.



Step 4: Create your test plan

What level of statistical confidence is right for you?

Before launching a test, determine the level of statistical confidence for the test, typically somewhere between 80%-99%.

Here are a few things to consider:

Select 90%, 95% or 99% confidence level, if...

If you have high volume of traffic, you can pick a higher level of confidence. You will reach confidence more quickly, and so can use a more rigorous confidence level.

If your conversion is an e-commerce transaction, consider using the highest level of confidence you can—from 95-99%. In your case, each conversion represents dollars in the virtual cash register, so you want to be as confident as you can in your test results before reaching a conclusion.

If the items you are testing are very derivative of each other and will likely have similar conversion rates, you may want to select a higher confidence level to ensure confidence in the results. If A is converting at 3% and B is converting at 3.5%, you want to run the test to a higher level of confidence.

Select 80% or 90% confidence level, if...

If you have low traffic volume, pick a lower level of confidence, so that you can cycle through tests at a reasonable rate and avoid the never-ending test wave.

If you are testing two very different things against each other—like a landing page against a radically different microsite—and you expect the conversion rate of each of the two will be pretty different, use a lower confidence level. It's easier to declare a winning test at 80% confidence when A is converting at 2% and B is converting at 20%.

Shorter test waves. Use for lower traffic levels. Less confident results. Use for innovation waves where results are likely to be different between A&B.

80%

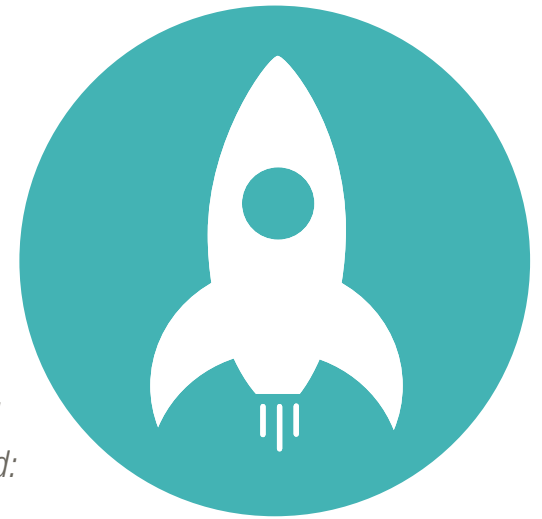
99%

Potential for longer test waves. Use for high traffic and ecommerce. More confident results.

Step 5: Run your test

Lights, camera, action!

You've created your challenger and documented your test plan. There's nothing left to do but launch! Using your landing page platform or testing tool, launch your test. Here are some tips to keep in mind:



Don't call the test too soon. When you launch your first few tests, you will probably sit and watch them happen in real time. Or at least keep tabs on the tests to see how things are going. This is a good idea. Keeping tabs on your active tests is a good way to monitor that nothing is amiss and keep your finger on the pulse of your traffic. But don't be tempted to call a test too soon. It may appear that one of the versions in your test is a clear winner. Just remember, it's not really a winner until statistical confidence is reached. Trust your landing page testing tool, sit back and let it calculate statistical confidence for you. You want to be sure of the results, and results can change before statistical confidence is reached.

Don't despair. You may have launched a dog of a test. It could be a test with no lift, where the control & challenger remain tied for conversion rate. It could be a challenger that actually performs worse than the control. When you find yourself in the midst of

a bad test, you have to keep your chin up. Every test can't be a winner. What's important is that you dig into analysis to uncover some learning to help feed into your next test. Many marketers who are just getting started launch a test with no result, throw up their arms, declare testing doesn't work and stop testing. Don't be that marketer. Stick with it, and you will get results.

Be ready to be wrong, be ready to be right. A challenger you are sure will beat the control might not. A challenger you aren't that enthusiastic about might lift conversions 100%. You just never know. Be the marketer who avoids getting dogmatic about what will and won't work, and instead be the one who says, "I don't know, let's test it".

Learn. A series of sound tests, documented with hypothesis and results, and analyzed at conclusion, will yield learning. Don't test just for testing sake. Test to lift conversions, and test to learn.

Step 6: Analyze your test

Bring an investigative mindset to maximize your learning

When your test reaches statistical confidence, it's time to start analyzing the pages to see what you can learn, and apply that learning to the next test wave. And remember to update your test plan document in the “what happened?” section, so you've captured results and can access them easily in the future.

When analyzing the results, you don't have to go too crazy—we're trying to avoid analysis paralysis. Here are just a few things to take a look at:

Bounce rate. A high bounce rate (75% or higher) indicates visitors aren't finding what they expect on your page. Seek to increase relevancy on your next test wave. A high bounce rate can also indicate you are providing too much information (overwhelming), or too little information (underwhelming), so consider content tests as well.

Conversion rate. We know, we know, this one's a given. Compare & contrast the conversion rate between the control and the challenger. Were they very different? If so, really inspect the page

with the higher conversion rate to make inferences about why it performed so much better than the page with the lower conversion rate. Were the test results actually pretty similar? Consider a radically different innovation for your next wave.



User behavior. If your landing page has clickable elements—like microsite navigation, segmentation choices, accordion or tabbed content—review which elements are being clicked on, and how likely visitors are to go on to convert after they engage with that element. This will help you determine which behaviors you want to increase, and which you want to try to minimize through layout, visual emphasis and content placement.

Traffic segment variance. If you ran a conversion path, did one audience segment convert very different from the other? Did you get many more of one segment than the other? Consider the role the traffic source may play in delivering the audience you want to your pages, and use this learning to help determine if you want to shift media allocation, or the conversion path layout to optimize for the audience that is most desirable.

Step 7: Keep on rolling



You're not stopping here, are you?

Whew, you did it. You tested a landing page! Now what?

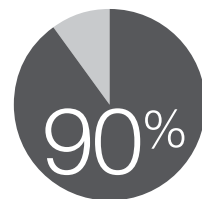
Keep on going. The approach outlined in How To Test can be adapted to any online marketing program—small or large. Use it for one landing page on one traffic source, or use it for hundreds of landing pages across 100 PPC traffic sources. The choice is yours. To scale your program methodically and effectively, let the organizational principles in How To Test guide you.

Start with traffic sources. Then move on to type of test, using sound testing tactics. Document each and every test wave using the who/what/where/when/why/what happened format, and use smart analysis to help you uncover your next steps and areas of opportunities when the test wave concludes.

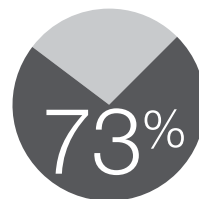
Try not to let your landing page testing initiative get more complicated than that.

These simple principles will lead you to success and great results—they work for us, they work for our customers, and they will work for you!

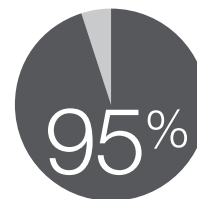
3 things you should know about ion



Positive ROI



100%
Improvement



Would
Recommend

TechValidate independent
research study of ion customers

ion Go beyond landing pages.

Turn your click throughs into business breakthroughs with ion.



Join customers like these that are transforming their landing experiences and their results with ion.

73% of our customers achieve 100%+ improvement in their digital marketing results, and more than half of them report 300-500% improvement. Join them!

Next steps for you to go beyond landing pages:

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- Check out all the free webinars and white papers in our [library](#).
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